Afro-Asian solidarity and hoped that China would be part of an effort to stop the spread of the Cold War.

China was initially hostile to Nehru's India, seeing it as a bourgeois junior partner of the Western imperial powers, and the commentary on Indian politics and policies was often critical, even contemptuous. The Korean war of 1950 began to change Beijing's view. India refused to join the US-led UN combat force in Korea and attempted to mediate between China and the US. Delhi's championing of China's membership of the UN and its steady criticism of the Western powers was helpful to Beijing and was an indication that Nehru was more independent of the West than the Chinese leadership had originally thought. The Afro-Asian meeting in Bandung turned out to be more of a triumph for Beijing than for Delhi – several Asian countries turned on India including Ceylon and Pakistan, and Zhou was the star of the show. India had introduced China to the newly independent countries only too well, to Beijing's advantage. The following year Delhi mounted a diplomatic attack on the Anglo-French intervention against Egyptian nationalization of the Suez Canal. This too would have impressed the Chinese.

To say that India and China were in an entente is to somewhat exaggerate the relationship. Both converged in their fear of US power, military and economic. They also converged in worrying that Asia might once again succumb to imperialism, with the American-led alliance system extending into the continent. Both therefore were critical of US policies, and both resisted – India diplomatically, particularly in multilateral organizations; and China militarily in Korea and, in time, in Vietnam. If there was an entente-like quality to their relationship, it was largely due to India's efforts – in Korea, in championing China's UN membership, in criticizing Western policies generally, and in promoting Beijing's entrée into Afro-Asian affairs.

Rivalry, 1959–1968